

Mei Yang

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EDUCATION

University of Chicago

MA · Computational Social Science

Chicago, IL

Sept 2026 – May 2028

- Midway Research & MA Director's Scholarships

University of Toronto

Honours B.Sc. · Psychology · GPA 3.88

Toronto, ON

Sept 2019 – June 2024

- Thesis: Coordination and power dynamics modeled via multi-agent reinforcement learning
- Awards: Dean's List 2019-24; University of Toronto Excellence Award 2023; Vision Sciences Society NEI Travel Grant 2024

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

SocialAI Research Group, University of Toronto

Toronto, ON

Research Technician

Sept 2025 – Aug 2026

- Built face stimulus sets in FaceGen via Python scripting against sparse documentation, normalizing race parameters on generated feature maps to make faces race-neutral while preserving distinct group boundaries per the study's design goal
- Developed and maintained a modular, well-documented jsPsych/Firebase/Qualtrics experiment pipeline for a two-phase online study examining repeated exposure as a mechanism of ingroup bias formation
- Coordinated iterative development with the lead researchers via a self-developed Notion workspace, centralizing institutional knowledge (e.g., FaceGen access protocols, stimuli versioning) across the project lifecycle

Population Well-Being Lab, University of Toronto

Toronto, ON

Lab Manager

Aug 2024 – Feb 2026

- Ran semi-structured interviews across a 7-person lab, tracing recurring project management tool adoption failures to low progress-visibility and surfacing conflicting adoption needs, from wanting structure to fearing wasted time
- Scoped the design to a single co-defined workflow, cutting non-essential features to reduce onboarding friction; achieved full-team adoption across 18 projects over a year, including the most resistant user
- Drove portfolio-wide accountability through weekly structured check-ins; 14 of 18 projects submitted for publication within the sprint cycle, with 2 published

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Population Well-Being Lab, University of Toronto

Toronto, ON

Independent Research Student (Advisor: Dr. Felix Cheung)

Oct 2023 - Ongoing

- Modeled individual well-being trajectories from 84-day experience-sampling data (105 participants, 8,925 observations), testing four cognitive model architectures via machine learning tournaments and a 6,560-specification multiverse analysis to show population averages mask real individual structure
- Found that well-being is driven primarily by subjective factors (affect, goal progress, value alignment) over objective ones, and identified three stable integration profiles plus a goal-decoupled subgroup (31%)

Bernhardt-Walther Lab, University of Toronto

Toronto, ON

Research Assistant (Advisor: Dr. Dirk Bernhardt-Walther)

Jan 2023 – May 2025

- Secured a \$7,500 research grant for an independently proposed study on bridge aesthetics; designed and ran three rating experiments (491 stimuli, 254 Prolific participants) using self-developed jsPsych-Firebase-Prolific pipeline
- Benchmarked aesthetic ratings against civil-engineering faculty's expert-defined bridge features using factor analysis (FAMD) and regression, linking specific design sub-features to aesthetic judgments; presented at VSS 2024 and co-authored the publication

PUBLICATIONS

- Yang, M., Damiano, C., Gauvreau, P., & Walther, D. B. (2025). The empirical aesthetics of bridge design. PLOS ONE. <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0338493>
- Chen, H., Yang, M., Son, G., Mack, M. L., & Walther, D. B. (2025). A large positive hysteresis effect for scene categories. Journal of Experimental Psychology: Human Perception and Performance. 10.1037/xhp0001416.
- Stutzman, L. D., Lun, P., Yang, M., Chan, K., & Cheung, F. (2025). Epilogue to the war: Afghanistan reports the lowest well-being in recorded history. Science Advances, 11(22). <https://doi.org/10.1126/sciadv.ads4156>

SKILLS

Programming & Analysis: Python (NumPy, Pandas), R, SQL
Experiment & Survey Tools: jsPsych, Qualtrics, Prolific